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Letter to Mayor White on accuracy of September Council meeting claims

Sent 25 September 2026 · To Mayor White, Communications Team · Response requested by 16 October 2026

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25 September 2026
Mayor Patricia White
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Accuracy of your public statements on the September ordinary meeting

Dear Mayor,

I have raised the accuracy of your public statements before.

I am writing again because your video message following the September ordinary meeting, and your remarks in the chamber on 22 September, contain statements that

are contradicted by Council's own published figures and,
in one case, by your own words at the meeting.

I am not suggesting you set out to mislead anyone.

But residents can check these things, and more of them now do. In part to the coverage of the Eye on Shoalhaven Council.

When a Mayor's account differs this far from the business paper, the webcast or Council's own website, a reader who checks the source is left to wonder whether the difference is carelessness or something worse. That damages your standing and the Council's, and it is avoidable.

The four statements are these.

1. **The response to the Community Infrastructure Strategic Plan. In the chamber on 22 September (CL26.220) you said:**

"29,000 comments were made on this … that's 50% of our ratepayers. 50% of our ratepayers made a comment. It's a quarter of the whole population of Shoalhaven made a comment."
Ordinary Meeting, 22 September 2026, CL26.220 (webcast transcript)

Council's Public Exhibition Summary Report records about 2,456 respondents. The figure of about 29,000 is the number of responses to individual draft recommendations, many made by the same people through the interactive map. Council's own CISP page described 5,448 responses across the three earlier campaigns as equivalent to about 4 per cent of the population. Around 2,456 people is nowhere near half of ratepayers or a quarter of the population. Your video repeats a version of this claim: "the biggest feedback I have ever seen on a thing in council".

1. The exhibition period. Your video says the plan was on public exhibition "over the last, well, probably 12 months". It was exhibited for one month, from 20 April to 20 May 2026.

1. Whether the recommendations come back to Council. Your video says: "All of those recommendations will come back to Council." In the chamber on 22 September you said the opposite, and objected to it:

"I have another problem with the report … is that only major capital works will come back to this council … what about all the minor projects — minor projects add up."
Ordinary Meeting, 22 September 2026, CL26.220 (webcast transcript)

Residents who rely on the video will believe they will get a second look at every recommendation. On your own account in the chamber, they will not.

1. Paid parking. Your video describes "paid parking that we want to do for non-residents". Council did not resolve to introduce paid parking. On CL26.222 it resolved to survey the community to test demand for a business case, with the results to come back to Council before any decision on that unfunded business case. You explained exactly that to councillors before the vote.

I ask you to do three things.

(a) Publish a correction of these four statements through the same channels the video was published on.

(b) Before making public statements about figures, consultation results or Council resolutions, check them against the business paper, the resolution or the responsible staff.

(c) Tell me whether you accept that the four statements above were inaccurate and, if not, on what basis.

I am publishing a fact-check of the video, setting each statement against the webcast and Council's documents. I will publish whatever response is received, including none.

Yours sincerely,

Steve Prothero
Publisher, Eye on Shoalhaven Council